

The longest air race of all was held in 1934. The MacRobertson race required competitors to fly from Mildenhall, England, to Melbourne, Australia – a distance of 11,300 miles (18,100km) across 19 countries and seven seas. Adventurous aviators from around the world rose to the challenge, although stringent entry conditions saw a field of only 20 entrants set off for Australia. Interestingly, aircraft in the race included both dedicated racers, such as the Granville “Gee Bee” flown by Jacqueline Cochran and Wesley Smith, and standard passenger-transport aircraft, such as the Boeing 247D piloted by Roscoe Turner and Clyde Pangborne.

In the event, the race was won by an airplane specifically designed for the occasion, the de Havilland D.H.88 Comet, flown by British airmen C.W.A. Scott and T. Campbell Black. Its performance was an extraordinary tribute to the progress that had been made in engines and airframes, in instrument flying, and also in the provision of facilities such as navigational aids and aerodromes along long-distance routes. The Comet reached Darwin, its first port of call in Australia, in 2 days, 4 hours, and 38 minutes. Fifteen years earlier the same journey had taken the Smith brothers 27 days 20 hours. But as striking as the winning time – 70 hours 54 minutes to

Melbourne – was the fact that the Comet was hard pressed by two passenger aircraft – a Douglas DC-2 entered by Dutch airline KLM, and Turner and Pangborne’s Boeing 247D. The DC-2 reached Melbourne only seven hours behind the Comet.

End of an era

By the time commercial airplanes were able to fly halfway across the world in a matter of days, the age of the celebrity pilot-heroes was drawing to a close. In 1938, only 11 years after Lindbergh’s celebrated Atlantic crossing, a Lufthansa Focke-Wulf Fw 200 Condor, a commercial airplane built to carry 26 passengers, flew nonstop from Berlin to New York in 25 hours. This did not exhaust the Condor’s range – from Germany it could even

AMELIA EARHART

KANSAS-BORN Amelia Earhart (1897–1937) was an average amateur pilot when she was invited to become the first woman to fly across the Atlantic. Her publicist (later her husband) judged her personality and looks suitable for promotion as a female Lindbergh. With no experience in instrument-flying, she could only travel as a passive third member in the Fokker trimotor that crossed the ocean in June 1928, but this did not prevent her from achieving celebrity status.



“LADY LINDY”

The press dubbed Earhart “Lady Lindy,” an association with Lindbergh that her publicists encouraged. During the 1930s she built up an impressive list of achievements to justify her fame.

formulate plans for an around-the-world flight in a Lockheed Electra with former Pan Am navigator Fred Noonan as her copilot. In March 1937, they set out westward from Oakland, California, but after crashing on takeoff, they decided it would be safer to fly eastward.

On May 2, 1937, they set out again, reaching Lae, New Guinea, by the end of June, having flown some 22,000 miles (35,200km). On July 2, 1937, a visibly exhausted Earhart took off on the 2,500-mile (4,000-km) leg to Howland Island, the last stop before California. She never arrived.

ALOHA FROM HAWAII

Amelia Earhart stands in the cockpit of her Lockheed Vega 5C after becoming the first person to fly solo from Hawaii to California on January 11–12, 1935.

